cramped in the rear seats, which is probably why Gary—an old man, you see, even then—changed his for a four-door Accord. One day at the Cliff, after we'd finished training for the day, I was getting ready to drive out of the parking lot and I already had someone sitting in the front passenger seat. David May came running over and asked if he could jump in the back. Well, I'd just got this beautiful new car and I said no. David swears to this day that what I actually said was: 'No chance. I don't want you to scuff the leather.'

It took about half an hour for everyone at the club to hear about it; and then several years for me to stop hearing about it. I don't remember saying it but—if I'm really honest with myself—I can imagine I did. I am particular about looking after the things I like and, in a soccer club dressing room, whether it's at Chase Lane Park or Old Trafford, that can get you into trouble. Soccer players will always find each other's weak spots and, once they do, they'll never leave it alone.

I've always had a streak in me, which might seem flashy if you don't know me, of being particular about the things I want and of valuing individuality, even if I get grief because of it. When I was about six years old I remember a family wedding where I'd been invited to be a pageboy. We all went along to get fitted for our outfits and I got my heart set on a particular look: maroon knickerbockers, white stockings up to the knee, a frilly white shirt, a maroon waistcoat and a pair of ballet shoes. My dad told me I looked stupid in it. Mum said she needed to warn me that people were going to laugh at me. I didn't care. I loved that outfit and I just wanted to wear it. Never mind at the wedding: I wanted it on all the time. I think I'd have worn it to school if they'd let me.

Along with being very particular about what I like, I'm very careful about looking after what I've got. My mum will tell you how, when I was at school, I used to come in and change but would only go out to play soccer after I'd folded up my dirty clothes. I'm still tidier than almost anyone else I know. When I first arrived at United, the other boys of my age weren't convinced about me, and maybe put some of my character, as they saw it, down to fancying myself a bit too much. The truth is, though—whether you're talking about a pageboy outfit, a club car with leather seats or a tattoo or a sarong—it's got nothing to do with one-upmanship or with making a point. My friends and my team-mates know that now, just as my family always have: I've got my own tastes and if I can indulge them I will, whatever other people might say. I've always been the same: knowing what I like is just part of who I am.

Everything that was happening away from soccer just added to the